
ENGL251-Communication Skills



Chapter 3 - Organizing and Drafting Your Message

Lesson Objectives:

After studying this chapter, you should be able to

3.1 **Research** to collect **background information** for messages.

3.2 **Organize** information into **strategic** relationships.

3.3 **Compose** a **first draft** using a variety of **sentence types** .

3.4 **Improve** your message by using **style** effectively.

3.5 **Organize** paragraphs **effectively** .

1 Prewriting

Analyze

- What is your purpose?
- What do you want the receiver to do or believe?
- What channel should you choose: face-to-face conversation, group meeting, email, memo, letter, report, blog, wiki, tweet, etc.

Anticipate

- Who is your audience?
- What does the receiver already know?
- How will the receiver's response be neutral, positive, or negative? How will this affect your organizational strategy?

Adapt

- What techniques can you use to adapt your message to its audience?
- How can you promote feedback?
- Strive to use positive, conversational, and courteous language.

2 Drafting

Research

- Gather data to provide facts.
- Search company files, previous correspondence, and the Internet.
- What do you need to know to write this message?
- How much does the audience already know?

Organize

- Organize direct messages with the big idea first, followed by an explanation in the body and an action request in the closing.
- For persuasive or negative messages, use an indirect, problem-solving strategy.

Draft

- Prepare a first draft, usually quickly.
- Focus on short, clear sentences using the active voice.
- Build paragraph coherence by repeating key ideas, using pronouns, and incorporating appropriate transitional expressions.

3 Revising

Edit

- Edit your message to be sure it is clear, concise, conversational, readable.
- Revise to eliminate wordy fillers, long lead-ins, redundancies, and trite business phrases.
- Develop parallelism.
- Consider using headings and numbered and bulleted lists for quick reading.

Proofread

- Take the time to read every message carefully.
- Look for errors in spelling, grammar, punctuation, names, and numbers.
- Check to be sure the format is consistent.

Evaluate

- Will this message achieve your purpose?
- Does the tone sound pleasant and friendly rather than curt?
- Have you thought enough about the audience to be sure this message is appealing?
- Did you encourage feedback?

1. Researching Background Information

- **RESEARCH** is essential **before** drafting a message:
 - Research involves collecting information about a specific topic
 - It helps **shape** the message and **build credibility**.
 - Business writers collect information to answer **several questions**:
 - What does the receiver need to know?
 - What is the receiver supposed to do?
 - How is the receiver supposed to do it?
 - When must the receiver do it?
 - What are the consequences if the receiver doesn't do it?
 - Research can be **informal or formal**, depending on the message purpose.
-

2. Informal Research Methods

- **Search company files:** Consult your own **files**, company **wiki**, and other **digital/manual files** for background information.
 - **Talk with your manager:** Gather information and guidance from your **manager**, who may have **knowledge** and **suggestions** on the topic.
 - **Interview the target audience:** Engage individuals from the intended audience to **gain insights** on their **needs** and **preferences**.
 - **Conduct an informal survey:** Utilize **questionnaires**, telephone **surveys**, or online surveys to gather helpful but **unscientific information**.
 - **Brainstorm for ideas:** Engage in **idea generation** sessions alone or in small **groups**, recording at least a dozen ideas without judgment.
-

3. Formal Research Methods

Complex business problems require **formal research methods**:

- **Access electronic sources** : digital catalogues, **Google search**
- **Search manually**: public and college **libraries** , books, articles, encyclopedias, reference books
- **Investigate primary sources**: visit **locations** , conduct traffic counts, search **blogs** and **social media**, use **questionnaires** , **interviews** , or **focus groups**
- **Conduct scientific experiments**: present choices with controlled variables

Examples of research topics for managerial decision making (related to clothing):

- Consumer **preferences** between Roots and H&M sweatpants
- Factors influencing **consumers' purchase** of sweaters, jackets, and cold-weather gear

Organizing Information to Show Relationships

- Organizing involves **GROUPING** and **STRATEGIZING** .
- Well-organized messages:
 - group **similar items together** and follow **a logical sequence**
 - Do not lack **emphasis** and do not confuse readers
- Two techniques for organizing data: **scratch list and outline**.
 - **Scratch list** → making a list of topics and writing the message from it
 - **Outlines** → organize complex ideas and provide clarity

Organization Strategies

DIRECT

recommended for **receptive audiences**.

main point is stated in the **first or second sentence**

Direct organization (frontloading) has three advantages:

- Saves the reader's time
- Sets a proper frame of mind
- Reduces frustration

suitable for ***routine requests, responses, orders, non-sensitive memos, emails, informational reports, and oral presentations.***

INDIRECT

appropriate for **uninterested, unwilling, displeased, or hostile audiences**

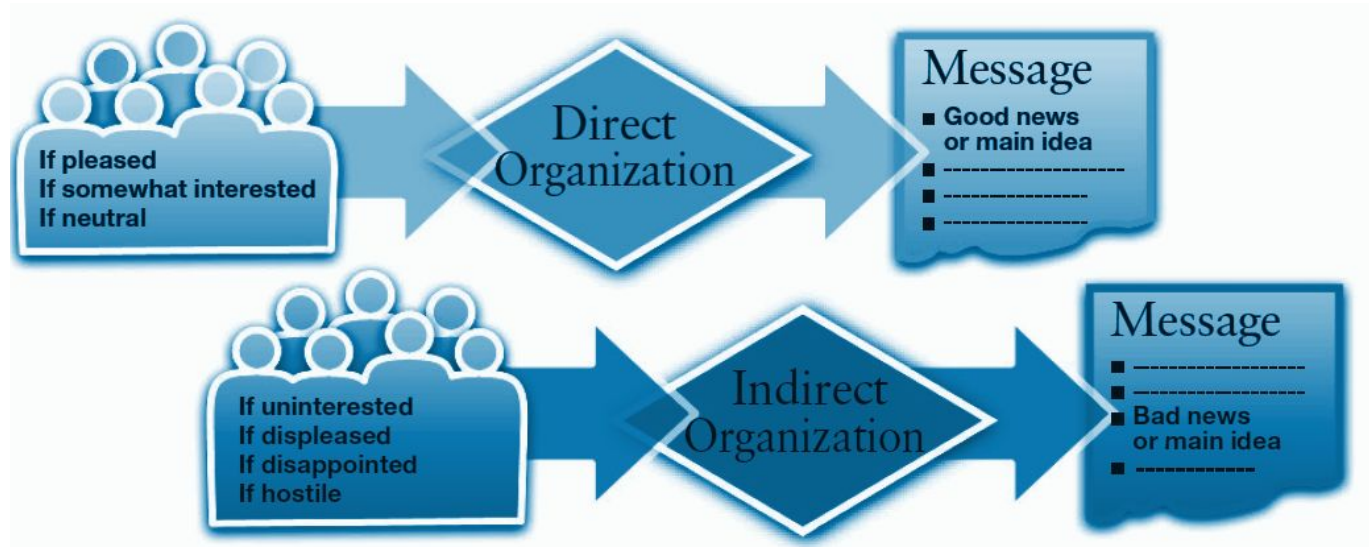
takes **longer** to get to the main idea.

beneficial for **bad news**, ideas requiring **persuasion**, and **sensitive news** transmitted to superiors

respects the audience's **feelings**, facilitates a fair hearing, and minimizes a negative reaction

suitable for messages that ***refuse requests, deny claims, disapprove credit, persuasive requests, sales letters, sensitive messages, reports, and oral presentations***

2.2

DRAFTING
ORGANIZE

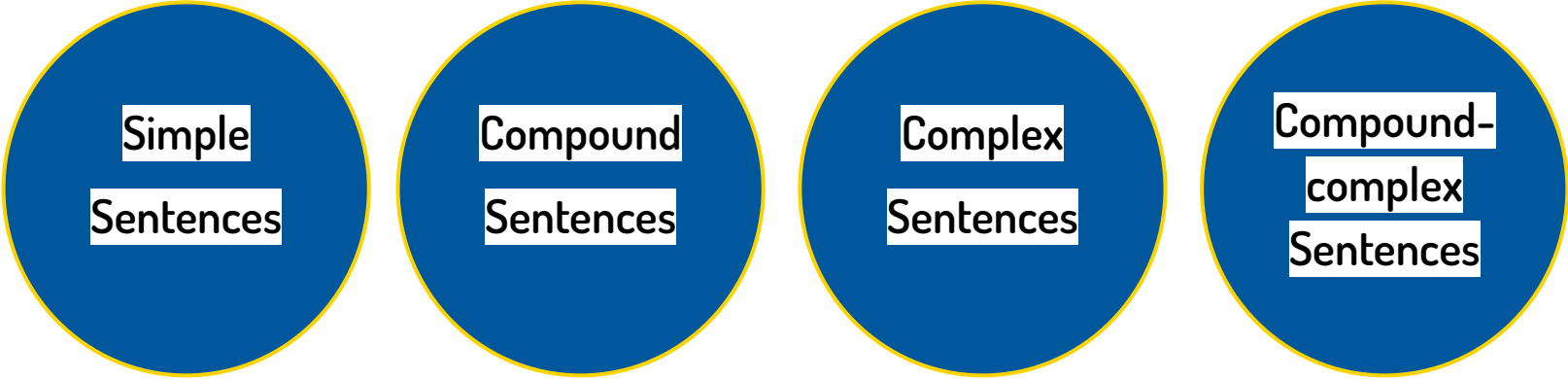
- There choice of organization depends on the **expected audience response** .
- Some messages may be a mix of **good news** and **bad news** or goodwill and persuasion .

You will practice applying direct and indirect organization in upcoming chapters.

Composing Drafts With Effective Sentences

- Organize ideas and create an **outline** to overcome writer's block
 - Minimize interruptions to maintain **focus**
 - Consider your preferred **writing style** :
 - **Freewriting** and **deliberate thinking** are both valid approaches
 - Write **quickly** to **capture** initial thoughts and **refine** them in **later** versions
 - **Imagine** speaking to the **reader** as you start each idea
 - Use **substitute words** or **placeholders** if you can't think of the right word at once
 - **Remember:** The first draft is NOT the final version; revisions and polishing can be done later.
-

a. Achieve Variety With Four Sentence Types



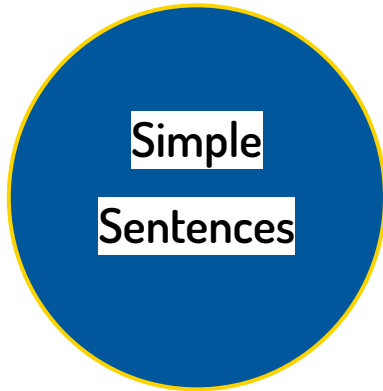
Simple
Sentences

Compound
Sentences

Complex
Sentences

Compound-
complex
Sentences

a. Achieve Variety With Four Sentence Types



It contains one complete thought with a subject and predicate verb.

Example: The entrepreneur saw an opportunity.

a. Achieve Variety With Four Sentence Types

It contains two complete but related thoughts.

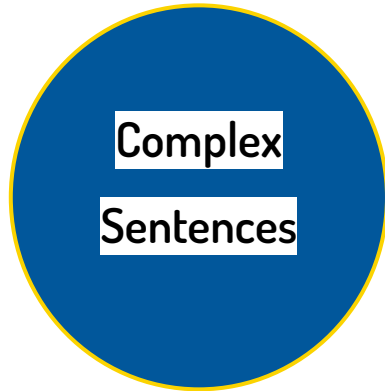
Examples:



Compound
Sentences

- The entrepreneur saw an opportunity, and she responded immediately.
 - The entrepreneur saw an opportunity; she responded immediately.
 - The entrepreneur saw an opportunity; consequently, she responded immediately.
-

a. Achieve Variety With Four Sentence Types



It contains an independent clause and a dependent clause.



Example: When the entrepreneur saw the opportunity, she responded immediately.

a. Achieve Variety With Four Sentence Types



Compound- complex Sentences

It contains at least two independent clauses and one dependent clause.

Example: When the entrepreneur saw the opportunity, she responded immediately; however, she needed capital.

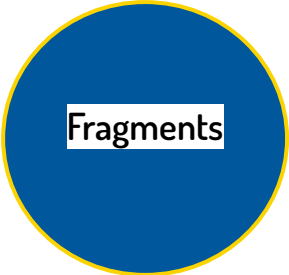
b. Avoid Three Common Sentence Faults

Fragments

Run-on
(fused)
sentences

Comma-splice
sentences

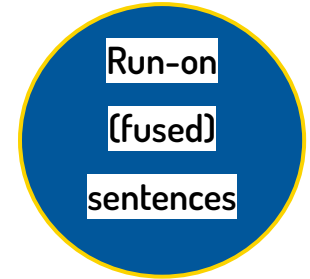
- Fragments are **broken-off parts** of complex sentences.
- Punctuating fragments as complete sentences is **a serious error**.
- Fragments can be identified by words such as *although, as, because, even, except, for example, if, instead of, since, such as, that, which, and when*.
- Add words to the sentence or remove words to fix fragments.



Fragments

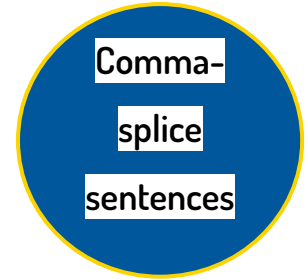
DON'T Fragment	DO✓ Revision
✗ <i>Because most transactions require a permanent record.</i> Good writing skills are critical.	✓ Because most transactions require a permanent record, good writing skills are critical.
✗ The recruiter requested a writing sample. <i>Even though the candidate seemed to communicate well.</i>	✓ The recruiter requested a writing sample even though the candidate seemed to communicate well.

- Two **independent** clauses in a sentence must be joined by a **coordinating conjunction (and, or, nor, but)** or a **semicolon (;)**
- Run-on sentence occurs when there is **no conjunction or semicolon**
- Run-on sentences should be avoided in writing



DON'T	Run-on Sentence	DO✓	Revision
✗	Many job seekers prepare traditional résumés some also use websites as electronic portfolios.	✓	Many job seekers prepare traditional résumés. Some also use websites as electronic portfolios.
✗	One candidate sent an email résumé another sent a link to her Web portfolio.	✓	One candidate sent an email résumé; another sent a link to her Web portfolio.

- **Comma splice** occurs when **two independent clauses** are joined by a **comma only**.
- Independent clauses can be joined by **coordinating conjunctions** or **conjunctive adverbs**. *Coordinating conjunctions require only a comma.*
- **Conjunctive adverbs** require a **semicolon** and a **comma**.



DON'T	Common Splice	DO✓	Revision
✗	Some employees prefer their desktop computers, others prefer their tablets.	✓	Some employees prefer their desktop computers, but others prefer their tablets.
		✓	Some employees prefer their desktop computers; however, others prefer their tablets.
		✓	Some employees prefer their desktop computers; others prefer their tablets.

c. Consider Short Sentences

- Communication should aim for sentences **around 20 words for clarity.**
 - Reader comprehension *decreases* as sentences become *longer*.
 - **Break complex sentences** into separate **segments** instead of using multiple conjunctions.
 - **Short sentences help business readers grasp ideas quickly.**
 - **Avoid** too many **monotonous short sentences** to maintain interest.
 - Strive for a **BALANCE** between longer and shorter sentences.
-

Develop Business **Writing** Techniques

1. Show Emphasis

IN CONVERSATION

- Emphasizing **main ideas** by speaking loudly or repeating them slowly
- Pounding the table for real emphasis
- Raising eyebrows, shaking the head, or whispering in a low voice

IN WRITING

- Using **mechanics** such as:
 - Underlining
 - *Italics* and **boldface**
 - **Font changes (size, style)**
 - ALL CAPS
 - Dashes – - (used sparingly)
 - Listing items vertically

1. Show Emphasis

Other means of mechanical emphasis:

- Arrangement of **space** , **color** , **lines** , **boxes** , **columns**
- **Titles** , **headings** , and **subheadings**
- **Software** and **color printers** offer **highlighting** capabilities

TIPS on structure

- Place the **important idea** **first or last** .
- Ideas have less competition from surrounding words when they appear first or last in a sentence.
- Give the **important idea** the **spotlight** .
- Don't dilute the effect of the **main idea** by making it **share the stage** with other words and clauses.
 - ➔ **Instead, put the main idea, separately, in a simple sentence or in an independent clause.**

2. Use the Active and Passive Voice Effectively

ACTIVE VOICE

- The **subject performs** the **action**.
 - is more direct, revealing the performer immediately
 - is easier to understand and usually shorter
- Most business writing should be in the active voice.

PASSIVE VOICE

- The **subject receives** the **action**.
 - useful for emphasizing actions over people
 - can de-emphasize negative news
 - can conceal the doer of an action

2. Use the Active and Passive Voice Effectively

Active Voice

Actor → Action
Justin must submit a tax return.

Actor → Action
Officials reviewed all tax returns.

Actor → Action
We cannot make cash refunds.

Actor → Action
Our CPA made a big error in the budget.

Passive Voice

Receiver ← Action
The tax return was submitted [by Justin].

Receiver ← Action
All tax returns were reviewed [by officials].

Receiver ← Action
Cash refunds cannot be made.

Receiver ← Action
A big error was made in the budget.

3. Develop Parallelism

Parallelism in structure creates **balanced writing**.

- Parallel sentences are **easy** to **read** and **understand** .
- **Avoid disturbing** the reader's expectations by maintaining parallelism in lists
- **Match** nouns with nouns, verbs with verbs, and clauses with clauses
- **Avoid mixing** active-voice verbs with passive-voice verbs.
- Use **similar structures** to express **similar ideas** for parallelism.
 - **Examples of parallel words: computing, coding, recording, storing**

4. Escape Dangling and Misplaced Modifiers

DANGLING MODIFIER

- **Example:** After **working** overtime, **the report** was finally finished.
- **Explanation:** The sentence implies that the report was working overtime.
- **Revised:** After working overtime, **we** finally finished the report.

MISPLACED MODIFIER

- **Example:** Firefighters rescued a dog from **a burning car** that had a broken leg .
 - **Explanation:** The sentence suggests that the car had a broken leg.
 - **Revised:** Firefighters rescued **a dog with a broken leg** from a burning car.
-

5. Drafting Well-Organized, Effective Paragraphs

- **Craft a Topic Sentence** : A unified paragraph develops a **single main idea** .
 - **Example:** "This report investigates consumer confidence changes in Canada in the past 10 years."
 - **Develop Support Sentences** : Add sentences related to the topic sentence to **discuss** and **explain details** .
 - **Build Paragraph Coherence:** Coherent paragraphs are **linked** ideas that lead logically from one to the next, taking readers through **a series of steps**.
 - Techniques for helping readers follow the writer's ideas include:
 - **Repeating a key idea using the same or similar expression.**
 - **Using pronouns to refer to previous nouns.**
 - **Showing connections with transitional expressions like:** *consequently,*
however, as a result, and *meanwhile.*
-

Thank you for your attention.

More on Revising in the 3x3x3 Writing
Process in the next chapter.
